



NURSING CAREER PATHWAY OVERVIEW

**Everything from CNA Certification to Becoming an RN
or NP**

Written by **CINDY ZHENG**

Nursing is one of the most flexible and rewarding careers in healthcare. There are multiple entry points, and you can climb the ladder as far as you want. Here's a clear breakdown of every track.

THE NURSING CAREER LADDER

Role	Education	Typical Salary (US)	Scope of Practice
CNA (Certified Nursing Assistant)	4-12 weeks of training + state exam	~\$30,000 - \$35,000/year	Provides basic care (bathing, feeding, vitals, mobility). Works under RN or LPN supervision.
LPN/LVN (Licensed Practical/Vocational Nurse)	1-year diploma/certificate + state exam	~\$45,000 - \$55,000/year	Administer medications, wound care, IVs (in some states). Works under RN or physician supervision.
ADN (Associate Degree in Nursing)	2-year community college degree + NCLEX-RN	~\$60,000 - \$75,000/year	Full RN scope: assessments, care planning, administering meds, patient education.
BSN (Bachelor of Science in Nursing)	4-year university degree + NCLEX-RN	~\$65,000 - \$85,000/year	Same as ADN, but leadership/management roles become more accessible.

			Many hospitals prefer BSN.
RN-to-BSN Bridge	For ADNs who want to upgrade to BSN (1-2 years online)	Same as BSN	Opens doors to management, public health, and advanced degrees.
MSN (Master of Science in Nursing)	2-3 years graduate school + certification (e.g., CNM, NP, CNS)	~\$100,000 - \$130,000/year	Advanced practice: Nurse Practitioner, Clinical Nurse Specialist, Certified Nurse Midwife, etc. Independent practice in many states.
DNP (Doctor of Nursing Practice)	3-4 years (often post-MSN)	~\$120,000 - \$150,000+	Highest clinical nursing degree. Focuses on leadership, policy, and advanced clinical practice.

CHOOSING YOUR PATH

If you're in high school:

Start with a BSN program directly—it's the fastest route to RN licensure and the most flexible.

If you're in college with a non-nursing degree:

Consider an Accelerated BSN (12-18 months for students with a bachelor's in another field).

If you want to start working ASAP:

Get your CNA certification (it's often covered by workforce development programs). Then, work while earning your ADN or BSN part-time.

If you want to become a provider (but not a doctor):

Aim for MSN or DNP → Nurse Practitioner. NPs can prescribe medications, order tests, and diagnose in most states.

REQUIRED CERTIFICATIONS BY ROLE

Role	Certification Exam	Renewal
CNA	State-specific CNA exam	Renew every 2 years
LPN/LVN	NCLEX-PN	Renew every 2-3 years
RN (ADN or BSN)	NCLEX-RN	Renew every 2-3 years + continuing education
NP	National Certification (e.g., AANP or ANCC)	Renew every 5 years

PRO TIPS

- **Shadow a nurse before committing—nursing is not just "doctor-lite"; it's a distinct profession.**
- **Look for tuition reimbursement programs—many hospitals will pay for your nursing degree in exchange for a 2-year commitment.**
- **Join the American Nurses Association (ANA) as a student—it's a great networking and resource hub.**

ABOUT THIS RESOURCE

This guide is part of the HealthBridge Library — free resources for every stage of your pre-health journey.

Contact: cindy@healthbridgeproject.org

Website: healthbridgeproject.org

Updated: June 2026

‘

This work is licensed under CC BY-NC 4.0